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India watched the army come out on the streets of Kolkata with a sense of disbelief. The presence of the army was the most emphatic show of no-confidence in Bengal's long-running CPI(M) Government and its leader Buddhadeb Bhattacharya. For 30 years, the CPI(M) has enjoyed favour with a sizeable number of Left liberals all over the country and hardly faced any opposition in its own backyard.

The Government in Bengal has had to deal with a paradigm shift in public mood and also the Left's national image. Chief Minister Bhattacharya, once the poster boy of the progressive Left, the darling of the middle class, the face of pragmatic Communism, is now battling for his political future. When he took over office after 23 years of Jyoti Basu's rule as chief minister, Bhattacharya slipped easily into the role of the maverick in the CPI(M). Here, we were told, was the odd man out in a party of crusty ideologues, a Leftist who could also be an icon for development and progressive thinking. The corporates could not stop cheering.

But in the last 11 months, everything Bhattacharya has done has gone horribly wrong. His liberalisation projects in Nandigram and Singur have proved to be political disasters. They have been pushed through without any resettlement plans or alternatives for those affected by them. The CPI(M) cadre, renowned for their discipline, have behaved like rampaging goons in Nandigram.

The Bengal intelligentsia whom Bhattacharya counted amongst his friends, is now opposing him on the streets. A protest in Kolkata over Nandigram suddenly grew to include the Taslima Nasreen issue. The demonstration led to riots and the imposition of a night curfew in some parts of Kolkata amidst fears of communal trouble.

Singur and Nandigram have marked a departure in Bengal politics. The Opposition Trinamool and the Congress have stepped in to cynically make political capital of the situation. For the CPI(M) in Bengal, all indicators are ominous. Every class affected by Bhattacharya's politics—the poor, the minorities—has united. The CPI(M)'s traditional vote bank has turned its wrath on the Government on economic issues.

This week's cover story looks at the slow decline of Bhattacharya, the future of Bengal and its place in the reforms process. The story was put together by a team led by Executive Editor, INDIA TODAY Bangla, Abhijit Dasgupta who sent in reports from Kolkata, along with Deputy Editor Damayanti Datta and Principal Correspondent Satarupa Bhattacharjya in Delhi who spoke to key members of the Left establishment for a national overview.

Bhattacharya had inherited a legacy precious to the Left: he was in charge of the world's longest-running democratically elected Communist government. But it is more than evident today that his brand of new-age Communism has failed. Ultimately this is bound to have repercussions at the Centre, where the Left plays a pivotal role.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)